

LESSON FIVE

LIGHT AND DARKNESS

Understanding the plan of salvation, and where you
stand in it

To understand the Plan of Salvation — what separates a person from God, what God has done about it, and how a person responds.

**Where are you right now
— in the darkness, or in
the light?**

- 01** You draw your own spiritual timeline before any teaching begins.
- 02** Scripture sets out the problem of sin and God's answer to it.
- 03** You come back to that timeline at the end and compare it with what Scripture says.

Before we open the Bible

What are your spiritual highlights?

Mark the moments that mattered — when you first heard about God, when you started asking questions, when something changed. Write the event above the line and roughly when it happened below it.

EVENT



WHEN

ASK **Three Questions**

When do you believe you were saved?

When did you receive the Holy Spirit?

When did you receive the forgiveness of sin?

Two Peoples, Two Conditions

1 PETER 2:9–10 NIV

⁹ But you are a chosen people, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, God's special possession, that you may declare the praises of him who called you out of darkness into his wonderful light. ¹⁰ Once you were not a people, but now you are the people of God; once you had not received mercy, but now you have received mercy.

1 PETER 2:9-10

Two Columns, No Middle

DARKNESS

Not a People of God

No Mercy

Lost

Not a Christian

Not a Disciple

LIGHT

People of God

Mercy

Saved

Christian

Disciple

Every person is either in the darkness or the light.
Peter gives no third category.

The list is not a scale from worse to better. It is one column or the other, and every line in a column moves together.

KEY TRUTH

**There is no twilight
zone. Where are you?**

The Problem, and Its Price

ROMANS 3:23 NIV

²³ for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God,

ROMANS 6:23 NIV

²³ For the wages of sin is death, but the gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.

UNDERSTAND

- For all have sinned, hence all people are condemned and in need of a savior.
- The penalty for sin is spiritual death, hence our spirit needs to be born again.

Born of Water and Spirit

JOHN 3:1-7 NIV

¹ Now there was a Pharisee, a man named Nicodemus who was a member of the Jewish ruling council. ² He came to Jesus at night and said, “Rabbi, we know that you are a teacher who has come from God. For no one could perform the signs you are doing if God were not with him.” ³ Jesus replied, “Very truly I tell you, no one can see the kingdom of God unless they are born again.” ⁴ “How can someone be born when they are old?” Nicodemus asked. “Surely they cannot enter a second time into their mother’s womb to be born!” ⁵ Jesus answered, “Very truly I tell you, no one can enter the kingdom of God unless they are born of water and the Spirit. ⁶ Flesh gives birth to flesh, but the Spirit gives birth to spirit. ⁷ You should not be surprised at my saying, ‘You must be born again.’”

- We must be born again of water and the spirit.
- This is a personal decision as an adult.

The Message to Believe

ACTS 2:22–24 NIV

²² “Fellow Israelites, listen to this: Jesus of Nazareth was a man accredited by God to you by miracles, wonders and signs, which God did among you through him, as you yourselves know. ²³ This man was handed over to you by God’s deliberate plan and foreknowledge; and you, with the help of wicked men, put him to death by nailing him to the cross. ²⁴ But God raised him from the dead, freeing him from the agony of death, because it was impossible for death to keep its hold on him.”

What message must one believe to be saved?

Cut to the Heart

ACTS 2:37 NIV

³⁷ When the people heard this, they were cut to the heart and said to Peter and the other apostles, “Brothers, what shall we do?”

What does it mean to be “cut to the heart”?

What Did They Do?

ACTS 2:38–42 NIV

³⁸ Peter replied, “Repent and be baptized, every one of you, in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins. And you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit. ³⁹ The promise is for you and your children and for all who are far off—for all whom the Lord our God will call.” ⁴⁰ With many other words he warned them; and he pleaded with them, “Save yourselves from this corrupt generation.” ⁴¹ Those who accepted his message were baptized, and about three thousand were added to their number that day. ⁴² They devoted themselves to the apostles’ teaching and to fellowship, to the breaking of bread and to prayer.

Once the people believed, what did they do?

- 01 Repent, turn to God.
- 02 Be baptized, be immersed in water.
- 03 **Their sins were forgiven. This is the point in time when a person is saved.**
- 04 The Holy Spirit is given to those who are baptized.

More Than a Symbol

ROMANS 6:3–8 NIV

VERSES 3 TO 5

³ Or don't you know that all of us who were baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death? ⁴ We were therefore buried with him through baptism into death in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead through the glory of the Father, we too may live a new life. ⁵ For if we have been united with him in a death like his, we will certainly also be united with him in a resurrection like his.

More Than a Symbol, continued

ROMANS 6:3–8 NIV

VERSES 6 TO 8

⁶ For we know that our old self was crucified with him so that the body ruled by sin might be done away with, that we should no longer be slaves to sin— ⁷ because anyone who has died has been set free from sin. ⁸ Now if we died with Christ, we believe that we will also live with him.

Baptism is the participation in the death, burial, and resurrection of Christ. It is more than just a symbol.

This is the point in time when we are freed from sin and united with Christ.

Baptism is not a picture of something that already happened. It is where it happens.

Two Tracks, One Pattern

	DEATH	BURIAL	RESURRECTION
JESUS	DIED	BURIED	RESURRECTED
OLD LIFE	Died with Christ	Buried with Christ	Raised to a new life

What happened to Jesus in history happens to a person at baptism. The pattern is the same and the order is the same: death, burial, resurrection.

What Crosses the Line

DARKNESS

Sin

Separates from God

Born Again

Of Water and Spirit

JOHN 3:5

ROMANS 3:25

Faith in the Blood of Jesus Saves Us

LIGHT

ACTS 2:38

Sin is Forgiven

ACTS 2:38

Water = Baptism

Spirit = Received at Baptism

Jesus shed his blood when he died. In baptism we share by faith in the death, burial and resurrection of Jesus. Thus our sins are covered through the blood of Jesus and we are forgiven and SAVED!

What Activates It

COLOSSIANS 2:11-12 NIV

¹¹ In him you were also circumcised with a circumcision not performed by human hands. Your whole self ruled by the flesh was put off when you were circumcised by Christ, ¹² having been buried with him in baptism, in which you were also raised with him through your faith in the working of God, who raised him from the dead.

What activates the power of God at baptism?

KEY TRUTH

It is our faith. We are saved by faith at the moment of baptism, not by the water itself.

Tradition Against Truth

MATTHEW 15:6–9 NIV

⁶ they are not to ‘honor their father or mother’ with it. Thus you nullify the word of God for the sake of your tradition. ⁷ You hypocrites! Isaiah was right when he prophesied about you: ⁸ “‘These people honor me with their lips, but their hearts are far from me. ⁹ They worship me in vain; their teachings are merely human rules.’”

False doctrines often arise from religious tradition. Two of them touch directly on what this lesson has just established.

1. INFANT BAPTISM

Refuted by Ezekiel 18:20, guilt is not inherited; and Luke 18:16–17, children already belong to the kingdom.

BEGAN

**approximately 2nd century
AD**

SOURCE NEEDED

BECAME CHURCH DOCTRINE

549 AD

SOURCE NEEDED • NAME THE COUNCIL

2. PRAYING JESUS INTO YOUR HEART

A misinterpretation of Revelation 3:20. That passage was addressed to baptized disciples, a church being called back, not unbelievers being invited in.

ORIGINATED **early 1800s America**

SOURCE NEEDED

REVELATION 3:20 NIV

²⁰ Here I am! I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in and eat with that person, and they with me.

Who is Jesus speaking to in Revelation 3? Read verses 14 and 19 before you answer.

This Water Now Saves You

1 PETER 3:18–22 NIV

¹⁸ For Christ also suffered once for sins, the righteous for the unrighteous, to bring you to God. He was put to death in the body but made alive in the Spirit. ¹⁹ After being made alive, he went and made proclamation to the imprisoned spirits— ²⁰ to those who were disobedient long ago when God waited patiently in the days of Noah while the ark was being built. In it only a few people, eight in all, were saved through water, ²¹ and this water symbolizes baptism that now saves you also—not the removal of dirt from the body but the pledge of a clear conscience toward God. It saves you by the resurrection of Jesus Christ, ²² who has gone into heaven and is at God's right hand—with angels, authorities and powers in submission to him.

What does the water represent in this passage? Noah's flood. In the same way the flood washed away the sinful people in Noah's time, baptism cleanses us of sin through Christ.

Baptism “now saves you”. This confirms again that baptism is not merely symbolic, but the moment our sins are forgiven by faith.

Review your timeline. Does it align with the Biblical process of salvation? If not, now is the time to repent and be baptized.

Turn back to the timeline you drew at the start of this lesson, before any of this was opened. Put a mark where Scripture says forgiveness, the Holy Spirit, and salvation are given. Compare the two.

ASK **Reflect and Respond**

Having read all of this, are you in the darkness or in the light? Write your answer, and the reason for it.

CHALLENGE

Respond urgently: be baptized for the forgiveness of your sins so you can be united with Jesus!

P R A Y E R

Father,

You called people out of darkness into your wonderful light, and you did not leave the way into it unclear.

Give me an honest heart about where I actually stand. Where I have trusted something you never promised, show me. Where I have delayed, give me urgency.

Thank you for the death, burial and resurrection of Jesus, and for making a way for me to share in it.

Amen.

NEXT

Lesson 6

Church

Understanding God's heart for His Church

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ACTS 2:42